As Haslam points out, ‘throughout the 1930s leading Conservative politicians with the democracies not only welcomed fascism into power but thereafter also feared that, were fascism overthrown in Italy or Germany […] communism would be almost certain to take its place.’[43] The communist menace was the number one consideration of European politicians in the interwar period, not Fascism or Nazism: ‘Britain’s secret intelligence service MI6 […] continued to see the Soviet Union as the main enemy through the middle of 1930s.’[44] The reason for this is that, ‘Britain emerged by default as the only global power and thus represented the greatest long-term threat to the survival of the Soviet regime.’[45] Stalin rightly sensed the difficulty with which Britain was trying to maintain the empire – he saw the latter as Britain’s Achilles heel. Conversely, ‘the Bolshevik threat to their empire had traumatised those who owned and ruled Britain. […] One immediate and symptomatic side effect was a noticeable indulgence towards Fascism, because of its decisive suppression of Communists.’[46]

The new states of Eastern Europe and their societies were not particularly unusual in their reactions to these developments: some were more sympathetic to the new ideologies, some less. Each of these countries was hoping to obtain security guarantees ahead of the expected forthcoming military conflict, which soon came to be seen as inevitable. Some, such as Hungary, began to slide towards their own form of nationalism, hoping perhaps to recover the pride and the territories lost in World War I. Czechoslovakia, Poland and Yugoslavia pursued a policy of thoroughgoing friendship with the Western Allies and also with the Soviet Union. They were very aware that they would be the first targets of Nazi and Fascist expansionist politics, as indeed they were.

In Yugoslavia, with the annexation of Austria in March 1938, Slovenians became the next-door neighbours of the Third Reich. This reinforced the appeasement efforts of Yugoslav government, including gestures to court the Nazi regime, some of them discriminating against Jews, at least on paper. Still, as late as December 1940, a conservative manifesto of the Slovenian People’s Party read: ‘We condemn capitalist and communist economic order. We reject a totalitarian state, formed in communism and fascism, which take away from other units of society and from individuals any autonomy and freedom.’[47] And already in 1933, the Slovenian